

Paint Correction Employee Training Guide

Employee Training • Paint Inspection • Correction Process • Quality Control

Purpose of this guide

This guide gives employees a consistent, professional way to assess paint defects, perform safe machine correction, and set accurate customer expectations. Paint correction is the highest-skill, highest-risk service Prime Auto Detail offers — done wrong, it can permanently damage a customer's vehicle.

CORE PRINCIPLE

***"Correction removes material to level a defect.
Every pass costs clear coat you cannot put back."***

Origination: Generated by Claude (Anthropic) for Prime Auto Detail, September 17, 2026

1. What Paint Correction Is — and Isn't

Paint correction levels the clear coat to reduce or remove swirl marks, holograms, light scratches, water etching, and oxidation. It works by **removing a microscopically thin layer of clear coat** until the surrounding area is level with the bottom of the defect.

Employee rule: Correction does not add anything to the paint — it removes material. There is a finite amount of clear coat on every vehicle, and it does not grow back.

2. Clear Coat & Safe Removal Limits

- Clear coat thickness varies by manufacturer, typically averaging 1.5–2 mils (thousandths of an inch) — but factory variance, prior repaints, and edges/high points can be significantly thinner.
- **[PLACEHOLDER: confirm whether you use a paint thickness gauge]** — if you use one, note the workflow here (check readings before/after each stage, flag panels below a safe threshold).
- Edges, body lines, and high points always have thinner clear coat than flat panel centers — extra caution required in these areas on every vehicle.
- Repainted panels (mismatched color, overspray on trim/rubber, thicker or thinner readings than surrounding panels) may have unknown or reduced clear coat — treat with extra caution or decline correction until verified.

3. Compounding vs. Polishing vs. Finishing

Stage	Purpose	Aggressiveness
Compounding (cutting)	Removes heavier defects — deeper swirls, oxidation, moderate scratches	Most aggressive
Polishing	Refines the surface after compounding, removes lighter marring	Medium
Finishing	Final refinement pass for maximum gloss and clarity	Least aggressive

Employee rule: Always work from most aggressive to least aggressive. Never skip straight to a finishing product on a heavily defected panel — it won't correct the defect, and you'll waste time and product.

4. Tools & Pad/Compound System

[PLACEHOLDER: insert your actual compound/pad product names here]

- Machine polisher: dual-action (DA) for most jobs — lower risk of burn-through; rotary reserved for experienced technicians on heavier correction only.
- Pad tiers: heavy cutting pad (wool or firm foam), medium polishing pad (foam), finishing pad (soft foam).
- **Pad discipline rule:** Never use the same pad across compound tiers — a pad that touched heavy-cut compound must be washed/dried before use with a lighter product, or use a dedicated pad per tier.

5. Step-by-Step Correction Process

- Fully wash, decontaminate (iron removal), and clay bar the vehicle before any machine work — correcting over contamination grinds debris into the paint.
- Tape off trim, rubber seals, badges, and plastic body cladding to protect them from compound sling and pad contact.
- Perform a **test spot** on a small, inconspicuous area first — confirm the pad/compound combination actually corrects the defect before committing to the full panel.
- Work in sections roughly 2x2 feet. Apply compound, work in overlapping crosshatch passes (horizontal, then vertical) at the machine manufacturer's recommended speed.
- Wipe the section clean and inspect under a dedicated inspection light (not ambient shop lighting) — direct light at an angle reveals swirls and holograms that overhead lighting hides.
- Follow with a polishing/finishing pass on the same section for maximum clarity.
- Once the full vehicle is corrected, wipe every panel down with an isopropyl alcohol (IPA) panel wipe to remove all compound/polish oils before applying any sealant, wax, or ceramic coating — residue left behind will prevent proper bonding.

6. Scenario Guidance

- **Dark paint (black, navy, dark gray):** Swirls and holograms are far more visible. Inspect more frequently under light during the process, not just at the end.
- **Soft OEM clear coats (common on newer vehicles, some import brands):** Correct with lighter pressure and a less aggressive compound first — soft clear coat corrects quickly and over-correcting is easy.
- **Single-stage paint (older vehicles, no separate clear coat layer):** Different process entirely — compound/polish works directly on the pigmented paint layer. Confirm before treating like a clear-coat vehicle.
- **Heavily oxidized paint:** May require a dedicated oxidation-removal compound pass before standard correction — do not attempt to correct through heavy oxidation with a finishing-tier product.

7. Common Mistakes to Call Out

- Skipping the test spot and committing the whole vehicle to an unproven approach.
- Too much pressure or dwell time in one spot — heat buildup from friction can burn through clear coat, especially on edges and high points.
- Cross-contaminating pads between compound tiers.
- Working in direct sun or on a hot panel — product dries too fast, reducing working time and correction quality.

- Skipping the IPA wipe-down before applying protection, causing poor bonding.

8. Customer Expectations & Script

Employee rule: Set the correction *level* expectation up front — a 1-step (polish-only) service reduces but does not eliminate defects; a full multi-stage correction gets closer to flawless but still may not remove very deep scratches down to primer.

"Paint correction improves the paint's clarity and reduces swirls and light scratches by carefully leveling the clear coat. It's not a magic eraser — very deep scratches that go down to the primer or base coat may lighten but won't fully disappear, since removing that much clear coat isn't safe for your paint. We'll assess your vehicle first and let you know realistically what level of correction will get you."

Quick Reference Rules

- Always wash, decon, and clay before machine work.
- Always test spot before committing to a full panel.
- Always work most-aggressive to least-aggressive.
- Never cross-contaminate pads between compound tiers.
- Always inspect under a dedicated light, not ambient shop lighting.
- Always IPA wipe-down before applying any protection product.